

Episode 114: New Year Special Edition – *STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM*

Notes (Indeed Middle Part 2)

"Hey there! Good work! Kobiki here!"

Kobiki-san, who appeared energetically, is a colour direction specialist mainly active on Toei works. She also participated in colour direction for *Casshern Sins*. This time, not as colour direction but as "assistant colour designer," I asked her to help me. I made an unreasonable request (really, quite an unreasonable request) for her to participate. From this day until the movie's completion, she'd be stationed in my room at Oizumi Studio.

For theatrical works over 90 minutes long, the general standard approach seems to be that colour design handles the design work in principle, with colour direction handled by someone else. Even for the theatrical *Legend of the True Saviour: Fist of the North Star* trilogy where I participated as colour designer under a "different name" at Tokyo Movie, we had 3-4 colour direction specialists participate in each.

However, for Toei Animation theatrical works, the colour design person handles both design and all colour direction alone as a rule. That's been Toei's traditional method since ancient times. I used to fight using that approach too. *GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!* movie from two years ago also used this method.

But while that might have worked in the old days with sufficient schedules, in today's situation with such tight deadlines, it's quite difficult. If you try to look at everything thoroughly and work out details, this method becomes impossible. I learnt this anew from *GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!* (though things like *PreCure* are still done this way even now...).

But at the same time, I personally have the desire to "do both colour design and colour direction completely myself."

I think any colour designer feels this way, but once you create characters and design scenes, you naturally want to do colour direction on the raw animation yourself and readjust the painted colours against backgrounds.

And this was also the director's wish. He wanted careful attention to details and a thoroughly substantial screen finish. So he wanted me to do all the colour direction and completion checking too. But to do everything properly alone, there simply wasn't enough time.

So this time, I absolutely needed someone to assist me. Enter Kobiki-san. Kobiki-san and I have weathered many battlefields together. We're comrades who understand each other's methods well. She's one of the colour direction specialists I trust most.

Work-wise, I would first do the overall colour design for the main feature, and I'd do all the colour direction alone. On top of that, I'd ask Kobiki-san to handle various somewhat time-consuming tasks that would take me too long if I started them myself.

One of these was organising mob scenes.

This work has an incredible number of pirates appearing. Kobiki-san handled creating colours for these pirates overall. First, creating colour direction data for pirates appearing across multiple cuts. Based on reference designs Sato-san provided for the pirates, she created colours for the pirate captains seated in the great hall during the "raid" scene, and used that data as colour direction reference for the finishing (仕上げ) staff to paint.

Then colour matching in actual painted cuts. Only a handful of pirate characters were roughly decided as designs, and the pirates actually appearing in cuts were mostly drawn by the key animators who handled those scenes & cuts as a series. She corrected and unified these painted results to avoid inconsistencies. Plus drinks and food in taverns,

swarms of pirate ships, and so on. She handled "difficult cut" after "difficult cut." That big pirate brawl mob scene during the "raid" sequence—that's all Kobiki-san's work.

Incidentally, what about painted completion inspection? Cuts painted overseas would first get a rough inspection from the team at Toei Animation mainly handling retake processing, checking for animation mistakes and missing masks. Then Kobiki-san and I would inspect all cuts once more together—that was our method.

So at that point, through "sorting," I'd ask Kobiki-san to handle cuts needing cross-cut matching, cuts needing colour corrections, cuts where I wanted to add processing later during colour direction, and she'd handle detailed processing work along with inspection. When I'd ask Kobiki-san "Make this 'on fire!'" she'd make it nicely 'on fire'—that kind of combination.

"Because you're touching actual key animation and in-between animation for colour direction, you can pay attention to detailed acting and nuances"—this is my theory about colour direction work. So my usual style is to inspect painted results of cuts I did colour direction for myself and add "one more spoonful." But in situations with tight schedules like this, it often becomes difficult to do such detailed "seasoning."

But thanks to Kobiki-san participating this time, she thoroughly covered parts I couldn't have handled alone and created several cuts beyond that.

Now then.

We got through September with its palpable sense of crisis and plunged into October. The month from here probably became the biggest "festival" in recent years. A dialogue between Oda-san and Mr. Children's Sakurai-san was scheduled for the first week of November. That meant we absolutely had to show them completed footage before that dialogue. Which meant completion by then...!

Aaagh! (waterfall sweat)

From here on, there are too many things that would cause problems for various parties to write about properly (wry laugh). Actually, during this one month, nearly 70% of the main feature's cuts flew around East Asia, and we somehow managed to reach completion.

Literally kicking young staff in the rear, sometimes raising our voices, somehow keeping the director motivated while running to the finish! Those days continued. A month that passed in a flash. I spent half of it sleeping in a sleeping bag in my studio room. Before I knew it, I'd become almost the oldest person on site, so there was also a month of fighting pressure, thinking that old guy had to work hard and set an example.

And so, we utterly exhausted staff faced November...

(10.01.27)